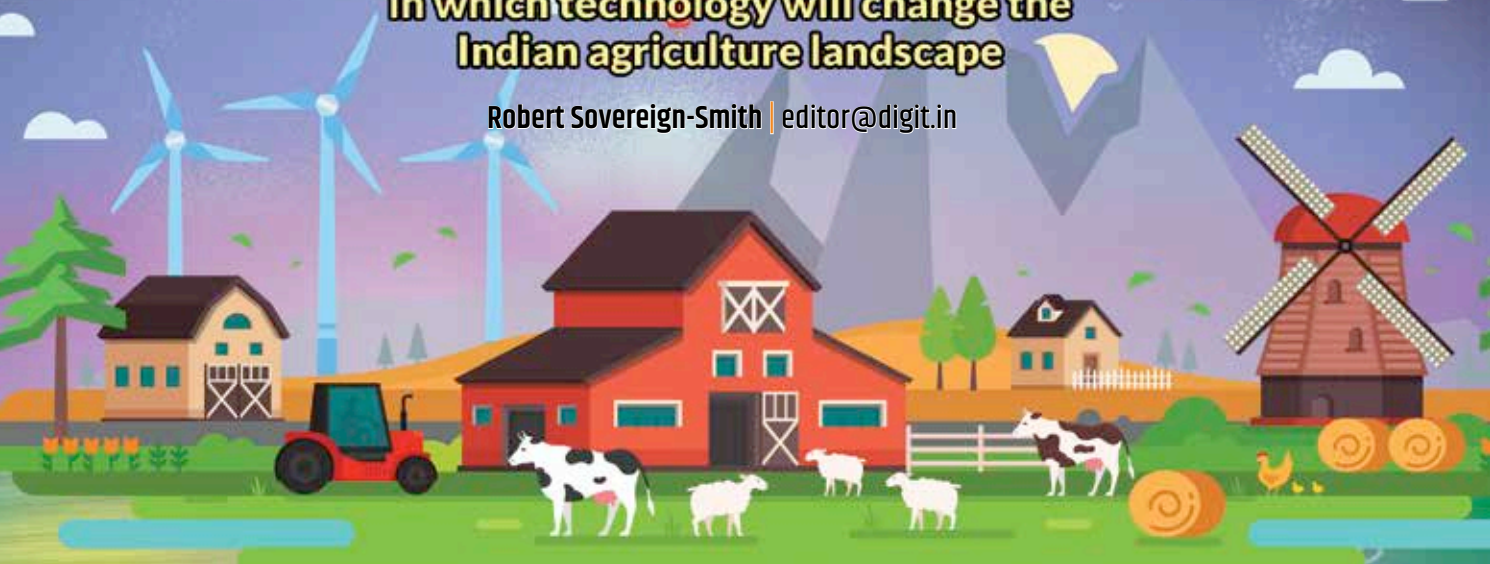


FOOD FOR THOUGHT

A quick look at some innovative ways in which technology will change the Indian agriculture landscape

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To be completely honest, we're a little guilty of focussing way too much on popular science and technology, and sometimes forgetting to touch upon the basics of what makes this country what it is. The only time we really talk about farmers is when they lose all hope and tragically commit suicide in sheer desperation. It's time we changed that.

Because of the news focussing on poverty and desperation and floods/droughts ruining farmers, those of us living in cities away from the farmlands have grown accustomed to thinking about them as poor desperate souls who struggle to make ends meet. While there is no doubt a lot of truth to that picture, we're also guilty of picturing them as simpletons who would be awed by the technology that we take for granted in everyday life. This isn't so at all.

Technology is not some rich person's tool that has some sort of wealth-

barrier. Perhaps it used to be back in the PCs heydays where an investment of at least 30k/40k was needed to just get started with tech. Perhaps it was even somewhat true when mobiles were dumb, and smartphones were expensive. It hasn't been true for nearly a decade now, though.

To most of us, innovation is considered to be something that's done whilst sitting in starbucks, sipping on a latte and staring blankly into the picture perfect sky as your mind wanders. We often forget that necessity is the mother of invention, and don't realise that a lot of innovations come from genuine pain – which is generally true for innovations in India's food production story.

AGRICULTURE

Although we've been moving more and more into technology, software services and manufacturing, India is still a farming country – almost 60% of the country still makes a

living primarily off food production. According to the IBEF (India Brand Equity Foundation – a trust set up by the Department of Commerce and the Government of India), 58% of the country has agriculture as their primary source of income. Of course, the contribution of agriculture to our GDP is falling slowly, as we diversify into other things as well, but most Indians are still, essentially, farmers.

Instead of this being a dumb listing of innovations, we're categorising the latest in the food production industry. These categories are:

1. Weather
2. Soil
3. Crops
4. Equipment
5. Sales and supply
6. Storage

WEATHER

If there's one thing that farmers depend on in order to sustain their crops, it's weather. Unfortunately,